

UTT Chapter 04 Assignment

Hello again!

Intramurals are getting pretty intense. We have competitions every weekend now. In fact, we had three this past week! Plus homework is starting to really take its toll on me. I'm tired and sore, both physically and mentally. I wish the weekend would hurry up and get here.

You remember Sarah, right? I told you about her a few weeks ago. She's pretty nice, but ever since I told her I was a Christian, she finds opportunities to mock my beliefs. I know she's just joking, but sometimes it seems hurtful. The other day in practice, I made a really bad shot. We had a shot to take the lead, and I majorly blew it. Embarrassed, I joked, "Sorry guys! My fault. I'm a *terrible* human being!" She laughed a little sarcastically and said, "The Bible says so, right?" I didn't really appreciate her tone, but I also didn't want her to know that some of her comments bothered me.

After the game, I apologized for missing the shot. I told her that everyone makes mistakes. She agreed, but she took issue with the Christian notion of sin. I didn't exactly see what that had to do with intramurals, but she went there regardless. Before too long, she was addressing just about every "superstition" that Christianity holds dear. I don't remember everything she said, but she went on and on about the Dark Ages, the Crusades, and even the Salem witch trials. I think the gist of her point is that religion is evil. I have never heard anyone talk about Christianity like that before. Sure, I was told that I might meet some atheists in college, but this wasn't quite what I expected.

Sarah calls herself a "Secularist." I kind of know what it means to be "secular," but I don't think I fully understand where Sarah is coming from. It just seems like she *disbelieves* everything I say. I know there's gotta be more! Maybe you could help me out! You've been learning about different worldviews in school. Have you learned anything about this stuff yet?

First off, **what is a Secularist?** I know Sarah doesn't believe in the Christian view of original sin, so **what does Secularism say about humanity?** And **what does it say is wrong with us, if anything?** And if she doesn't go to church or tithe or read the Bible, what exactly *does* she do? **What does Secularism say about how we should live?** It makes my head hurt trying to figure all this stuff out. I can't believe you are learning about this kind of thing in high school. It would be great if you could help me!

I gotta go. My friends invited me to a pool tournament in the student center. I've been practicing, but I just learned how to play last month!

Wish me luck!

-Doug

Doug brought up four different questions; below is a rough outline of possible responses:

1. What is a Secularist?

A Secularist is someone who adheres to both naturalism and materialism. **Naturalism** says everything that happens in the universe has a natural explanation. **Materialism** is the philosophical belief that reality is composed solely of matter. Since the secular worldview denies both God and the supernatural, Secularism isn't concerned with the afterlife. In fact, one of the defining characteristics of Secularism is the disdain shown for worldviews that believe in the immaterial and supernatural. Secularists are solely concerned with the present. They focus on advancing humanity through science and reason, without making any appeals to the divine. To this end, Secularists advocate for a government and public system of education devoid of appeals to God-belief or supernatural religion. [4.3, 4.5, 4.7–4.8]

2. What does Secularism say about humanity?

Secularism is firmly grounded in the naturalistic theory of evolution. According to Secularism, human beings are merely evolving animals. Besides our highly evolved intelligence, there isn't much that sets us apart from the rest of the animal kingdom. Like everything else in the world, human beings are merely comprised of matter. We don't possess a soul, and we aren't immortal beings. Our mind is just a physical brain, nothing more. When we die, the matter that makes up who we are simply stops moving, and we cease to exist. [4.9b]

3. What does Secularism say is wrong with us?

According to Secularism, the problem with humanity is that we are not all sufficiently disenchanted with spiritual things. As Secularists see it, all of reality is steadily progressing toward a better world. As we evolve, we become more advanced. History is the progression from non-life to life, simple to complex, unintelligent to intelligent. Human beings advance in our understanding of science, the world, and our understanding of morality because we have learned to direct our own progress. Anything that stands in the way of our advancement is considered evil. Since religion is perceived as such an inhibitor, Secularists generally dismiss any given religion and its adherents. [4.9c]

4. What does Secularism say about how we should live?

Since Secularists deny the relevance of God, it follows that they also deny the existence of an absolute moral code based on anything immaterial or supernatural. According to Secularism, morality is a biological product of evolution, not revelation handed down from above. As we observe animals in

nature, we find that they follow a rudimentary standard of ethics. Human evolution has developed a similar, though much more advanced, system of morality. As we continue to evolve, our morality will evolve along with us. Utilizing reason, human beings formulate complex ethical systems for living that function much like the Christian concept of natural law, though without an appeal to the divine. Unlike the Christian conception of unchanging objective standards, an evolving morality is seen more like a set of adjustable guidelines. Secularists don't deny that morality exists; they just deny that morality has a supernatural source. [4.9d]